VARUN KULKARNI

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EDUCATION

Cornell SC Johnson College of Business — **New York, NY**
Master of Business Administration (STEM-designated) — **5/2027**
- Merit Scholarship; Fellow, Cañizares Center for Emerging Markets (EMC²); coursework: Designing & Building AI Solutions
- Co-founder and Treasurer, Fintech Club; member, Product Management Club, AI Club, Big Red Tech

Maharashtra Institute of Technology (MIT), Savitribai Phule Pune University — **Pune, India**
Bachelor of Engineering, Mechanical Engineering — **5/2017**

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

NATIONAL PAYMENTS CORPORATION OF INDIA (NPCI) — **Mumbai, India**
Operator of UPI, India's real-time consumer payments network (530M+ users, 22B+ monthly transactions); fast-track promotion

Lead, Product Development – UPI — **2/2025 – 5/2026**
- Led UPI's on-device, PIN-less biometric payment authentication from 0 to 1, idea to national launch in 8 months (co-inventor, patent pending); scaled to 30M+ daily transactions and 15M daily active users
- Simplified the experience through research: ran user interviews, field visits and A/B tests through partner apps, found that offering PIN and biometric together confused users, and shipped biometric as the default with PIN as the fallback
- Built it as a platform capability: defined the functional architecture, API specifications and partner certification with engineering so all 33 consumer apps integrated it, coordinating ~100 organizations through launch
- Raised payment success rate 1.5% over PIN by removing incorrect-PIN declines; reached 30M+ enabled users in 6 months; tracked adoption against north-star, supporting and counter metrics
- Designed for trust: kept biometric data on the device for privacy under India's data protection law, defined device-binding rules to prevent spoofing and fraud, and negotiated new liability standards with banks and regulators
- Owned platform strategy and roadmap; segmented users by usage and digital literacy from field research and built a growth plan for under-served segments around voice and feature-phone payments, adding 5M new users in 3 months toward a 10M target
- Automated executive adoption reporting over an ~800K-row dataset using ChatGPT and Gemini to generate code; led a 5-person team across features, including an internal Llama-based assistant prototype

Lead, UPI International (promoted from Senior Associate, 7/2023) — **4/2023 – 1/2025**
- Single point of contact for 7 executive sponsors across two companies, running weekly executive reviews; enabled merchant acceptance in 7 countries including UAE, Singapore and France and grew international adoption 4x in 18 months
- Drove a platform update that let new international partners connect without changes by domestic banks; lifted global QR adoption to 95% across major volume-contributing apps and success rate from ~45% to 98%
- Took cross-border money movement from 0 to 1: ~20K direct international remittances and ~10K non-resident Indians paying with foreign mobile numbers; won RBI approval for policy changes for inbound travelers

Senior Associate, Product Development – AePS (Aadhaar-enabled rural banking platform) — **7/2021 – 3/2023**
- Reduced platform fraud 85% (1,000 to 150 cases/month) by leading integration and evaluation of an AI/ML fraud-detection model with engineering, data science and partner banks; analyzed efficacy and false positives with banks
- Drove adoption of face authentication to 20M+ monthly transactions, improving accessibility for rural users whose worn fingerprints failed to read and reducing reliance on fingerprint hardware

JIO PAYMENTS BANK — **Mumbai, India**
Manager, Product — **1/2021 – 7/2021**
- Launched a nationwide agent-banking channel across 50,000+ retail shops; owned policy, onboarding and compliance, and led UI/UX flows with design for agents and first-time users

FINO PAYMENTS BANK — **Mumbai, India**
Officer, Product — **1/2020 – 1/2021**
- Owned a B2B API banking platform: led 40+ partner integrations and raised technical success rate from 96% to 98% through incident analysis with support teams and partners; framed the partner commission model

Officer, Business Analyst — **1/2018 – 1/2020**
- Launched an automated balance-transfer product with a partner bank, defining use cases, user stories and requirements and owning testing; scaled to 200K+ customers ("Above & Beyond Call of Duty" award, 2019)

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

- Skills: product strategy, user research, A/B testing, API specifications, product analytics, SQL, Tableau, Figma, Balsamiq, AI tools (Claude Code, ChatGPT, Gemini, Lovable)
- Recognition: NPCI "Well Done" award (2025); Speaker, Global Fintech Festival 2023; Guest lecturer, Digital Fifth fintech cohort
- Certifications: IIM Calcutta Executive Certificate in FinTech & AI (2026); XLRI Executive Development Program, Strategic Management
- Interests: certified paragliding pilot (P2), high-altitude trekking, Formula 1